

Chapter 4 — Tribals, Dikus and the Vision of a Golden Age

The one-line point: Colonial rule needed **settled, countable, taxable subjects**. Tribal India was **mobile, forest-based and outside the revenue net** — so it was reclassified, restricted and dispossessed. **Birsa Munda's answer was a golden age and a Munda Raj.**

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Syllabus Classification

Field	Value
Subject	History → Modern India
Sub-discipline	Colonial social & environmental history ; tribal resistance
Period	19th century – 1900
Prelims (GS Paper I)	★★ <i>History of India</i> → tribal revolts and their dates , forest laws, Birsa Munda
Mains (GS Paper I)	★★★ INDIAN SOCIETY — tribal marginalisation; also " <i>important contributors from different parts of the country</i> " in the freedom struggle
Also feeds	Indian Society (GS1) ★★★, Polity ★★ (Fifth Schedule, PESA 1996, Forest Rights Act 2006 — this chapter is their justification), Environment ★★ (forest policy, community rights), Ethics (dispossession and dignity)
Weightage	★★★★ — tribal revolts are a recurring Prelims set; very high Mains value for GS1
Overlaps with	Class 7 Ch.5 (tribes before colonialism), Class 12 Theme 10 (Rebels and the Raj)

Learning Outcomes

By the end of this chapter you should be able to:

- ☐ **Describe *jhum* cultivation** step by step and define ***bewar*** and **broadcasting**. ★★
- ☐ **Classify** tribal livelihoods — shifting cultivators, hunter-gatherers, herders, settled cultivators — with named examples. ★★
- ☐ **Explain** why trade and moneylending meant **debt and poverty**, using the **silk cocoon** case. ★★★
- ☐ **Explain** what happened to **tribal chiefs** under colonial rule. ★★
- ☐ **Explain** why the British wanted shifting cultivators **settled** — and why it failed. ★★
- ☐ **Describe the forest laws, Reserved Forests, and the** ★ **forest villages** device. ★★★
- ☐ **List the tribal revolts with dates.** ★★★
- ☐ **Narrate Birsa Munda's life, his vision of a golden age, his political aim, and the two lasting outcomes.** ★★★
- ☐ **Define *diku*** and explain who counted as one.
- ☐ **Connect** this chapter to the **Fifth Schedule, PESA and the Forest Rights Act.** ★★

Start Here: 1895, Chottanagpur

*"In **1895**, a man named **BIRSA** was seen roaming the forests and villages of **Chottanagpur in Jharkhand**. People said he had **miraculous powers** — he could cure all diseases and multiply grain. Birsa himself declared that **God had appointed him to save his people from trouble, free them from the slavery of DIKUS (outsiders)**. Soon thousands began following Birsa, believing that he was **bhagwan** and had come to solve all their problems."

Fact	Detail
His people	Born into a family of ★ MUNDAS , a tribal group of Chottanagpur
His following	Included other tribals of the region — ★ SANTHALS and ORAONS
★ The grievance	"Their familiar ways of life seemed to be disappearing, their livelihoods were under threat, and their religion appeared to be in danger."

★ **DIKU** = **outsider**. The chapter's whole argument is about **who became an outsider on land that had been tribal**, and how.

🔗 **Class 7 Ch.5 recap NCERT gives:** most tribes had **customs and rituals very different from those laid down by Brahmans**, and **lacked the sharp social divisions of caste society** — all members shared **common ties of kinship**. ⚠️ **But NCERT adds a caveat worth keeping:** "*this did not mean that there were **no social and economic differences within tribes**.*"

1 ★ ★ How Tribal Groups Lived — Four Livelihoods

Some were *jhum* (shifting) cultivators ★ ★

THE JHUM CYCLE, step by step

- [1] Done on **SMALL PATCHES** of land, **MOSTLY IN FORESTS**
- [2] Cultivators **CUT THE TREETOPS** to allow **SUNLIGHT** to reach the ground
- [3] **BURNT** the vegetation on the land to clear it
- [4] **SPREAD THE ASH** from the firing -- it **CONTAINED POTASH** -- to **FERTILISE** the soil
- [5] Used the **AXE** to cut trees and the **HOE** to scratch the soil
- [6] *** **BROADCAST** the seeds *** -- i.e. **SCATTERED** them on the field **INSTEAD OF PLOUGHING** the land and sowing
- [7] Once the crop was harvested, they **MOVED TO ANOTHER FIELD**
- [8] A field cultivated once was **LEFT *** FALLOW ***** for several years

Term	Meaning
★ Broadcasting	Scattering seeds instead of ploughing and sowing
★ Fallow	A field left uncultivated for a while so the soil recovers fertility
★ Bewar	The term used in Madhya Pradesh for shifting cultivation

Where: "*Shifting cultivators were found in the **hilly and forested tracts of NORTH-EAST and CENTRAL India**.*"

★ ★ **The critical dependency, and the reason the forest laws were devastating:**

*"The lives of these tribal people depended on **FREE MOVEMENT WITHIN FORESTS** and on **being able to use the land and forests for growing their crops**. That is the **ONLY** way they could practise shifting cultivation."*

Restrict movement and you do not merely inconvenience them — you abolish their agriculture.

🏹 **Some were hunters and gatherers** ★

The KHONDS of the forests of **Orissa**:

Practice
Went out on ★ collective hunts and divided the meat amongst themselves
Ate fruits and roots from the forest
★ Cooked with oil extracted from the seeds of the SAL and MAHUA
Used many forest shrubs and herbs for medicinal purposes
Sold forest produce in local markets
★ Local weavers and leather workers turned to them for ★ KUSUM and PALASH flowers to colour cloth and leather

★ **That last line matters:** tribal forest produce was an **input to settled village crafts**. The forest and the plains were **economically interdependent**, not separate worlds.

★ **Sal** = a tree; **mahua** = a flower that is eaten or used to make alcohol.

★ **The Baigas' refusal:** when forest produce shrank, tribal people had to wander in search of wage work —
*"But many of them — like the **BAIGAS of central India** — were **reluctant to do work for others**. The Baigas saw themselves as **people of the forest, who could only live on the produce of the forest**. ★ **It was BELOW THE DIGNITY** of a Baiga to become a labourer."*

🎯 **This is not stubbornness; it is an identity claim.** For a GS1 answer on tribal marginalisation, it shows that the loss was **not only economic but of self-definition** — becoming a wage labourer meant ceasing to be who you were.

💰 ★ ★ ★ Why market and commerce meant debt

Tribal groups "often needed to BUY AND SELL in order to get the goods NOT PRODUCED WITHIN THE LOCALITY."

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"This led to their DEPENDENCE ON TRADERS AND MONEYLENDERS."

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TRADERS came around with things for sale and "sold the goods at HIGH PRICES"

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MONEYLENDERS gave loans with which tribals met their cash needs -- "but the INTEREST charged was usually VERY HIGH"

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*** "So for the tribals, MARKET AND COMMERCE OFTEN MEANT DEBT AND POVERTY." ***

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"They therefore came to see the MONEYLENDER AND TRADER as EVIL OUTSIDERS and the CAUSE OF THEIR MISERY."

★ ★ This is the specific content of the word **diku**. Not "non-tribal" in the abstract — **the trader and the moneylender**, the two figures through whom the outside world extracted value.

🐄 Some herded animals ★

Group	Where	Animals
★ Van Gujjars	Punjab hills	Cattle
★ Labadis	Andhra Pradesh	Cattle
★ Gaddis	Kulu	Sheep (shepherds)
★ Bakarwals	Kashmir	Goats

💡 Learn these four pairings — a stock matching question. (*The Gaddis also appeared in Class 7 Ch.5, in the western Himalaya.*)

🚜 Some took to settled cultivation

Even before the nineteenth century many had **settled down**, using the **plough** and gradually acquiring **rights over land**.

★ In many cases, like the MUNDAS of Chottanagpur, the LAND BELONGED TO THE CLAN AS A WHOLE. All members were regarded as **descendants of the original settlers who had first cleared the land**, so **all of them had rights on it**.

⚠️ But: "very often some people within the clan **acquired more power than others**, some became **chiefs** and others followers. **Powerful men often rented out their land instead of cultivating it themselves**."*

★ ★ ★ **Hold on to "the land belonged to the clan as a whole."** This is the exact principle colonial land settlement destroyed — because settlement required **individual owners**, and there was no column in the form for a clan. **It is also the principle that PESA and the Forest Rights Act later tried to restore.** (Compare the Ahom rule in Class 7 Ch.5: the king could not take land without the community's consent.)

★ **And the colonial hierarchy of judgement:**

*"British officials saw **settled tribal groups like the GONDS and SANTHALS as MORE CIVILISED** than hunter-gatherers or shifting cultivators. **Those who lived in the forests were considered to be WILD AND SAVAGE: they needed to be SETTLED AND CIVILISED.**"*

🎯 **Settledness was equated with civilisation** — and, not coincidentally, with **taxability**. The moral judgement and the fiscal interest pointed the same way.

2 ★ ★ What Happened to Tribal Chiefs

BEFORE the British	UNDER British rule
Important people enjoying economic power	★ Allowed to keep their land titles over a cluster of villages and to rent out lands
Had the right to administer and control their territories	★ Lost much of their ADMINISTRATIVE POWER
In some places had their own police	★ Forced to follow laws made by British officials
Decided the local rules of land and forest management	★ Had to PAY TRIBUTE to the British
Held authority among their own people	★ Had to DISCIPLINE THE TRIBAL GROUPS ON BEHALF OF THE BRITISH
Fulfilled traditional functions	★ "They LOST THE AUTHORITY they had earlier enjoyed amongst their people, and were UNABLE TO FULFIL THEIR TRADITIONAL FUNCTIONS."

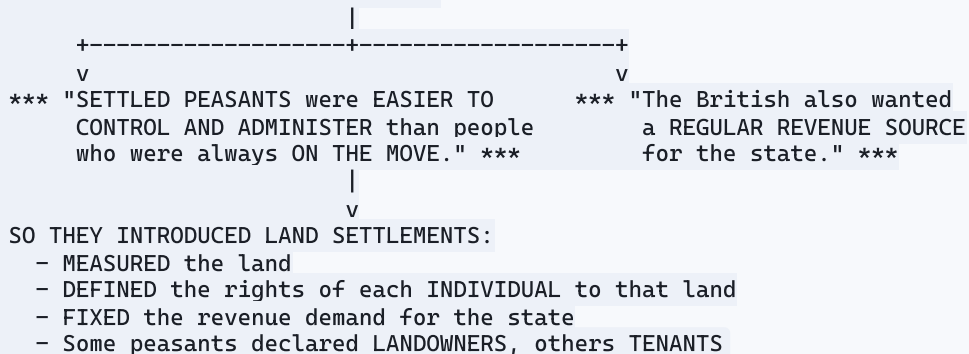
★ ★ **The chief was kept as an economic figure and hollowed out as a political one** — retained as a rent-collector and enforcer, stripped of the functions that had made him legitimate. **He became an agent of the state among his own people**, which destroyed exactly the authority the state wanted to use.

🖨 **The role was preserved and its permissions revoked.** He kept the title and lost the capability — and with it the consent that made the title work.

3 ★★ The Attack on Shifting Cultivation

WHY THE BRITISH WANTED THEM SETTLED

"The British were UNCOMFORTABLE with groups who MOVED ABOUT and did NOT HAVE A FIXED HOME."



⚠️ ★★ Why it failed — and the one British retreat in the chapter

*"The British effort to settle jhum cultivators was **NOT VERY SUCCESSFUL**. Settled plough cultivation is **NOT EASY** in areas where **WATER IS SCARCE** and the **SOIL IS DRY**. In fact, jhum cultivators who took to plough cultivation **OFTEN SUFFERED**, since their fields did not produce good yields."*

★★★ *"So the jhum cultivators in **north-east India** **INSISTED** on continuing with their traditional practice. **FACING WIDESPREAD PROTESTS**, THE BRITISH HAD TO ULTIMATELY ALLOW THEM THE RIGHT TO CARRY ON SHIFTING CULTIVATION IN SOME PARTS OF THE FOREST."*

★★★★ **This is an important and often-missed point: resistance WORKED here.** Sustained protest forced the colonial state to **concede a legal right**. When a Mains question asks whether tribal resistance achieved anything, this is your first piece of evidence — the second being Birsa's land laws at the end of the chapter.

🎯 **And note the technical argument:** *jhum* was not primitive backwardness. It was **an adaptation to dry soil and scarce water**, and plough agriculture in those conditions **produced worse yields**. The "civilising" policy was **agronomically wrong**.

4 ★★ Forest Laws and Their Impact

"The life of tribal groups was **directly connected to the forest**. So **changes in forest laws** had a **considerable effect** on tribal lives."

[1] "The British EXTENDED THEIR CONTROL OVER ALL FORESTS and declared that *** FORESTS WERE STATE PROPERTY. ***"

[2] Some forests were classified as *** RESERVED FORESTS ***
-- "for they produced TIMBER WHICH THE BRITISH WANTED"

[3] In these forests people were *** NOT ALLOWED TO: ***
- MOVE FREELY
- practise JHUM CULTIVATION
- COLLECT FRUITS
- HUNT ANIMALS

[4] "How were jhum cultivators to survive in such a situation?
*** MANY WERE THEREFORE FORCED TO MOVE TO OTHER AREAS
IN SEARCH OF WORK AND LIVELIHOOD. ***"

👤 ★★ ★ The forest villages device — a genuinely cynical solution

THE BRITISH PROBLEM:

"Once the British STOPPED the tribal people from LIVING INSIDE FORESTS, they faced a problem.
*** From where would the Forest Department get its LABOUR to CUT TREES for RAILWAY SLEEPERS and to TRANSPORT LOGS? ***"

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THEIR SOLUTION:

"They decided that they would GIVE JHUM CULTIVATORS SMALL PATCHES OF LAND IN THE FORESTS and ALLOW THEM TO CULTIVATE THESE -- *** ON THE CONDITION *** that those who lived in the villages would have to *** PROVIDE LABOUR TO THE FOREST DEPARTMENT and LOOK AFTER THE FORESTS. ***"

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"So in many regions, the Forest Department established
*** FOREST VILLAGES *** to ensure a *** REGULAR SUPPLY OF CHEAP LABOUR. ***"

★★ ★ Look at the structure of this, because it is the sharpest thing in the chapter.

Step 1: take away their right to live in the forest. Step 2: give a fraction of it back — as a wage.
The very access that had been theirs by custom was **reissued as payment for labour the state needed.**

They were made dependent on the state for what they had previously simply had. That is the mechanism of colonial forest policy in one paragraph, and it is superb Mains material for GS1 and for Environment.

★ **Sleeper** = the horizontal planks of wood on which railway lines are laid. The railways — the great symbol of colonial "modernisation" — **ran on timber cut by dispossessed forest dwellers.**

★★ ★ Resistance to the forest laws:

"Many tribal groups reacted against the colonial forest laws. They disobeyed the new rules, continued with practices that were declared illegal, and at times rose in OPEN REBELLION. Such was the revolt of ★ SONGRAM SANGMA in 1906 in ASSAM, and the ★ FOREST SATYAGRAHA of the 1930s in the CENTRAL PROVINCES."

★ And the Baiga song Verrier Elwin recorded in the 1930s — worth quoting:

*"In this land of the English how hard it is to live... In the village sits the **landlord**, In the gate sits the **Kotwar**, In the garden sits the **Patwari**, In the field sits the **government**... **To pay cattle tax we have to sell cow / To pay forest tax we have to sell buffalo / To pay land tax we have to sell bullock / HOW ARE WE TO GET OUR FOOD?**"*

🎯 **Four figures occupying four spaces — village, gate, garden, field — so that there is nowhere left to stand.** And the second verse states the trap exactly: **each tax must be paid by selling the animal that produces the food.** This is a tribal voice in the historical record, and it is precisely the sort of source Chapter 1 said was hardest to recover.

5 ★★ ★ The Problem with Trade — the Silk Case

The best worked example of tribal exploitation in the book.

THE SILK COCOON CHAIN, Hazaribagh (present-day JHARKHAND)

The SANTHALS reared cocoons



Traders' AGENTS gave LOANS to the tribal people and COLLECTED the cocoons



*** The growers were paid Rs 3 to Rs 4 for a THOUSAND cocoons ***



These were exported to BURDWAN or GAYA



*** ...where they were sold at FIVE TIMES THE PRICE ***



The MIDDLEMEN -- "so called because they ARRANGED DEALS between the EXPORTERS and the SILK GROWERS" -- *** MADE HUGE PROFITS. ***
*** "The silk growers earned VERY LITTLE." ***



"Understandably, many tribal groups saw the MARKET and the TRADERS as their MAIN ENEMIES."

★★ The "five times the price" figure is asked directly. And the analytical point is worth stating in an answer: the SantHALs bore all the production risk and captured none of the value, because they were tied by debt to a single buyer and had no access to the market where the price was actually set.

🔗 Exactly the *ryoti* indigo structure from Chapter 3 — advance, obligation, low price, permanent debt. The same instrument, applied to a different community and commodity.

🔪 The search for work

From the late nineteenth century, tea plantations came up and mining became an important industry. ★ Tribals were recruited in large numbers to work at the TEA PLANTATIONS OF ASSAM and the COAL MINES OF JHARKHAND.

★★ "They were recruited through CONTRACTORS who paid them miserably low wages, and PREVENTED THEM FROM RETURNING HOME."

★ **The scale and the cost:** in the **1920s**, **about 50 per cent of the miners** in the **Jharia and Raniganj** coal mines of Bihar **were tribals**. Work deep in the dark, suffocating mines was *"not only back-breaking and dangerous, it was often literally killing"* — ★ **over 2,000 workers died every year in India's coal mines in the 1920s.**

★ **"Prevented them from returning home" is indentured labour in all but name.** This is the destination of dispossession: a forest-dweller who could not live in the forest ended up **a mine worker who could not leave.**

6 ★ ★ ★ Tribal Revolts — Learn These Dates

*"Through the nineteenth and twentieth centuries, tribal groups in different parts of the country **rebelled against the changes in laws, the restrictions on their practices, the new taxes they had to pay, and the exploitation by traders and moneylenders.**"*

Revolt	Year	Where
★ ★ KOLS rebelled	1831–32	Chottanagpur
★ ★ SANTHALS rose in revolt	1855	(Santhal Pargana)
★ SONGRAM SANGMA's revolt	1906	Assam
★ ★ BASTAR Rebellion	1910	Central India
★ Forest Satyagraha	1930s	Central Provinces
★ ★ WARLI Revolt	1940	Maharashtra
★ ★ ★ BIRSA MUNDA's movement	1895–1900	Chottanagpur

💡 A stock Prelims format is match-the-revolt-to-the-year or to the region. **Learn all seven.**

★ **And note the span: 1831 to 1940 — over a century of continuous tribal resistance.** This is the "resistance was continuous, not occasional" thread from the index. **The countryside was in revolt long before, and long after, the Congress existed.**

The making of a leader

Influence	What he absorbed
Birth	Born in the ★ mid-1870s , " <i>the son of a poor father</i> "; grew up around the forests of Bohonda , grazing sheep, playing the flute, dancing in the local <i>akhara</i> . Forced by poverty, his father had to move from place to place looking for work
★ The sirdars	As an adolescent he heard tales of the Munda uprisings of the past and saw the <i>sirdars</i> (leaders) urging the people to revolt . They spoke of a golden age when the Mundas had been free of the oppression of <i>dikus</i> , and said the ancestral right of the community would be restored . They saw themselves as descendants of the original settlers, fighting for their land (MULK KI LARAI)
★ The missionary school	"He heard it said that it was possible for the Mundas to attain the Kingdom of Heaven and REGAIN THEIR LOST RIGHTS — if they became good Christians and gave up their 'bad practices'"
★ A Vaishnav preacher	He wore the sacred thread and began to value the importance of purity and piety

★ ★ Birsa's movement is a **synthesis**, and NCERT is careful about this. He drew on **Munda tradition, Christian millenarianism and Vaishnav asceticism** — and then **turned against the missionaries and landlords**, seeing them as "*outside forces that were ruining the Munda way of life.*"

🎯 He took the promise of the missionaries — that lost rights could be regained — and **detached it from the missionaries**. That is a sophisticated observation for a Mains answer on tribal millenarian movements.

🇮🇳 ★ ★ ★ The vision of a golden age

In **1895**, Birsa urged his followers to **recover their glorious past**. He talked of a golden age — a ★ **SATYUG, the age of truth** — when the Mundas:

- **constructed embankments**
- **tapped natural springs**
- **planted trees and orchards**
- **practised cultivation to earn their living**
- **did not kill their brethren and relatives**
- **lived honestly**

★ "*Birsa also wanted people to **once again work on their land, SETTLE DOWN and CULTIVATE their fields.***"

★ **The reform side:** his movement "*was aimed at **reforming tribal society.***" He urged the Mundas to **give up drinking liquor, clean their village, and stop believing in witchcraft and sorcery.**

🎯 NCERT's own question — "why do you think such a vision appealed to the people of the region?" — has a real answer.

The golden age was **not nostalgia for hunting and wandering**; it described **embankments, orchards, honest cultivation and settled land**. It offered **dignity and security in a familiar idiom** — a past that was recognisably theirs, and a future in which the land was theirs again. **A vision of restoration is more mobilising than a vision of change**, because it claims what is being demanded was **already rightfully yours**.

✂️ ★ ★ ★ The political aim — what actually alarmed the British

"What worried British officials most was the **POLITICAL AIM** of the Birsa movement, for it wanted to **DRIVE OUT MISSIONARIES, MONEYLENDERS, LANDLORDS, AND THE GOVERNMENT** and **SET UP A MUNDA RAJ WITH BIRSA AT ITS HEAD**."

★ And why each was named:

Target	The grievance
The government	"The land policies of the British were destroying their traditional land system "
Landlords and moneylenders	"were taking over their land "
Missionaries	"were criticising their traditional culture "

The course of the movement

1895 -- As the movement spread, British officials decided to act:
*** ARRESTED BIRSA, convicted him of RIOTING,
and JAILED HIM FOR TWO YEARS ***

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1897 -- RELEASED. He began TOURING THE VILLAGES to gather support,
"using TRADITIONAL SYMBOLS AND LANGUAGE to rouse people,
urging them to *** DESTROY "RAVANA" (dikus and the
Europeans) *** and establish a kingdom under his leadership"

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His followers targeted the SYMBOLS of diku and European power:

- ATTACKED POLICE STATIONS and CHURCHES
- RAIDED the property of MONEYLENDERS and ZAMINDARS
- *** RAISED THE WHITE FLAG as a symbol of BIRSA RAJ ***

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1900 -- *** BIRSA DIED OF CHOLERA and the movement faded out. ***

★ The use of "Ravana" is worth noting — a familiar mythological idiom repurposed for anti-colonial mobilisation, exactly as the *satyug* was. **Resistance spoke in the language people already had.**

★ ★ ★ Why it mattered — the two outcomes NCERT names

"However, the movement was **significant in at least TWO ways**:

★ ★ **FIRST** — it **forced the colonial government to INTRODUCE LAWS** so that the **LAND OF THE TRIBALS COULD NOT BE EASILY TAKEN OVER BY DIKUS**.

★ ★ **SECOND** — it showed once again that **the tribal people had the CAPACITY TO PROTEST AGAINST INJUSTICE** and **express their anger against colonial rule**. They did this in their **own specific way, INVENTING THEIR OWN RITUALS AND SYMBOLS OF STRUGGLE**."

★ ★ ★ **The first outcome is the direct ancestor of a whole line of Indian law**, and this is the connection to make in a GS1 or GS2 answer:

Birsa's movement → the Chotanagpur Tenancy Act (1908) → the Fifth and Sixth Schedules of the Constitution → PESA (1996) → the Forest Rights Act (2006).

The principle running through all of them is the one this chapter opened with: **tribal land belongs to the community and cannot be freely alienated to outsiders.** (*Compare the Ahom rule in Class 7 Ch.5 — the king could not take land without the community's consent.*)

★ **And the second outcome is NCERT's answer to a persistent condescension** — that tribal people were passive victims of history. **They resisted continuously, and on their own terms, with their own symbols.**

Prelims

Topic	The exact thing to know
Diku ★	Outsider — above all the trader and the moneylender
Jhum steps ★★	Cut treetops → burn → spread ash (potash) → axe and hoe → broadcast seeds → move → leave fallow
Bewar ★	Shifting cultivation in Madhya Pradesh
Khonds ★	Orissa ; collective hunts; sal and mahua oil; kusum and palash flowers for dyeing
Baigas ★	Central India ; refused wage labour as below their dignity
Herders ★★	Van Gujjars (Punjab hills), Labadis (Andhra), Gaddis (Kulu, shepherds), Bakarwals (Kashmir, goats)
Munda land ★★	Belonged to the CLAN as a whole ; all members were descendants of the original settlers
British view ★	Gonds and Santhals (settled) seen as more civilised ; forest-dwellers as wild and savage
Tribal chiefs ★★	Kept land titles , lost administrative power ; paid tribute ; had to discipline their own people
Forests ★★★	Declared state property ; Reserved Forests for timber ; no free movement, jhum, fruit-gathering or hunting
Forest villages ★★	Land in the forest in exchange for labour to the Forest Department — a regular supply of cheap labour
Sleeper ★	Planks on which railway lines are laid
The jhum concession ★★	Facing widespread protest , the British allowed shifting cultivation in some parts of the forest in the north-east
Silk case ★★★	Santhals of Hazaribagh ; paid Rs 3–4 per thousand cocoons ; sold at FIVE TIMES the price in Burdwan or Gaya
Migration ★★	Tea plantations of Assam , coal mines of Jharkhand ; recruited by contractors who prevented them from returning home
Mining ★	1920s : ~50% of miners at Jharia and Raniganj were tribals; over 2,000 deaths a year
Revolts ★★★	Kols 1831–32 , Santhals 1855 , Songram Sangma 1906 (Assam) , Bastar 1910 , Forest Satyagraha 1930s (Central Provinces) , Warli 1940 (Maharashtra)
Birsa ★★★	Born mid-1870s , Munda ; arrested 1895 , jailed two years ; released 1897 ; white flag of Birsa Raj ; died of cholera in 1900
Satyug* / *mulk ki larai ★★	The age of truth / the fight for the land
Two outcomes ★★	Laws protecting tribal land ; and proof of tribal capacity to protest
Verrier Elwin ★	British anthropologist who lived among the Baigas and Khonds in the 1930s–40s

Traps:

- "Jhum cultivators plough the land and sow seeds" → **FALSE**. They **broadcast** seeds without ploughing (*NCERT true/false*)
- "The British wanted to preserve the tribal way of life" → **FALSE** (*NCERT true/false*)
- "Tribal chiefs lost their land titles under British rule" → **FALSE**. They **kept the titles** and lost the **administrative power**
- "Reserved Forests were set aside to protect tribal rights" → **FALSE**. They were reserved for **timber** the British wanted

- "The British never conceded anything to shifting cultivators" → FALSE. They **allowed jhum** in some parts of the forest after protests
- "Birsa's movement had only religious aims" → FALSE. Its **political aim** was a **Munda Raj**, driving out government, landlords, moneylenders and missionaries

Mains

- ★★ ★ **Indian Society (GS1):** "Colonial forest and land policy transformed tribal communities from independent forest-dwellers into dependent labour." — use **Reserved Forests + forest villages + the silk chain + mine recruitment**
- ★★ ★ **Polity (GS2):** trace **community land rights** from Munda clan ownership → Birsa's laws → **Fifth Schedule** → **PESA 1996** → **Forest Rights Act 2006**
- ★★ **Environment:** *ghum* as an **ecological adaptation**, not backwardness; the agronomic failure of imposed plough cultivation
- ★★ "Tribal resistance was continuous and occasionally effective." — the *ghum* concession and Birsa's land laws as evidence
- ★ **Historiography:** Verrier Elwin's songs as a rare tribal voice in the record

Glossary

Term	Meaning
Diku	Outsider
Jhum / Bewar	Shifting cultivation / its name in Madhya Pradesh
Broadcasting	Scattering seed instead of ploughing and sowing
Fallow	Land left uncultivated to recover fertility
Sal / Mahua	A tree / a flower eaten or used to make alcohol
Kusum / Palash	Flowers used to colour cloth and leather
Reserved Forest	Forest reserved by the state for timber, with access barred
Forest village	A settlement allowed in the forest in exchange for labour
Sleeper	Horizontal wooden plank under railway lines
Sirdar	A leader of the Munda community
Mulk ki larai	The fight for the land
Satyug	The age of truth; the golden age
Vaishnav	A worshipper of Vishnu
Middleman	One who arranges deals between producer and exporter

2-MINUTE RECAP

1. **Dikus** = outsiders — in practice the **traders and moneylenders** through whom tribal people met the market, and for whom "market and commerce often meant **debt and poverty**."
2. **Four livelihoods:** **ghum** cultivators (cut, burn, **ash for potash, broadcast**, move, leave **fallow**), **hunter-gatherers** (Khonds of Orissa — *sal, mahua, kusum, palash*), **herders** (Van Gujjars, Labadis, Gaddis, Bakarwals), and **settled cultivators** (Mundas, where **land belonged to the clan as a whole**).

3. **The Baigas refused wage labour** — it was **below their dignity** as people of the forest.
4. **Tribal chiefs kept their land titles but lost administrative power**, paid **tribute**, and had to **discipline their own people** for the British — destroying their authority.
5. The British wanted shifting cultivators **settled** because settled peasants were **easier to control and taxable**.
 ★ **It failed** — plough cultivation gave poor yields on dry soil, and after **widespread protests the British allowed jhum in some parts of the forest**.
6. ★★ **Forests were declared state property; Reserved Forests** were closed to movement, jhum, fruit-gathering and hunting. Then, needing labour for **railway sleepers**, the state created ★ **forest villages** — giving back small patches of forest **in exchange for labour**.
7. **Resistance to forest laws: Songram Sangma, 1906, Assam; the Forest Satyagraha of the 1930s** in the Central Provinces. **Elwin's Baiga song**: "*To pay forest tax we have to sell buffalo... how are we to get our food?*"
8. ★★ **The silk chain**: Santhals of **Hazaribagh** paid **Rs 3–4 per thousand cocoons**, resold in **Burdwan or Gaya at five times the price** — the **middlemen made huge profits**.
9. **Dispossession ended in migration: tea plantations of Assam and coal mines of Jharkhand**, recruited by **contractors** who paid miserably and **prevented them from returning home**. In the **1920s half the miners at Jharia and Raniganj were tribals**, and **over 2,000 died yearly**.
10. ★★ **Revolts: Kols 1831–32, Santhals 1855, Songram Sangma 1906, Bastar 1910, Forest Satyagraha 1930s, Warli 1940** — and **Birsa, 1895–1900**.
11. ★★ **Birsa** drew on **Munda tradition, missionary promise and Vaishnav piety**, then turned on the missionaries. He preached a **satyug** of **embankments, orchards and honest cultivation**, and a return to **settled land**.
12. ★★★ **His political aim was a MUNDA RAJ** — driving out **missionaries, moneylenders, landlords and the government**. **Arrested 1895, released 1897**, his followers attacked police stations and churches under a **white flag**; he **died of cholera in 1900**.
13. ★★★ **Two outcomes**: the government was **forced to legislate against the easy transfer of tribal land**, and tribal people demonstrated their **capacity to protest, in their own idiom**. That legal principle runs down to **PESA and the Forest Rights Act**.

Test Yourself

Prelims style

1. Fill in the blanks: (a) The method of sowing seeds in jhum cultivation is known as _____. (b) Tribals went to work in the _____ of Assam and the _____ in Bihar. → (a) *broadcasting* (b) *tea plantations; coal mines*.
2. State whether true or false: (a) Jhum cultivators plough the land and sow seeds. (b) Cocoons were bought from the Santhals and sold at five times the purchase price. (c) The British wanted to preserve the tribal way of life. → (a) *False* — they **broadcast** seed. (b) *True*. (c) *False*.
3. Consider the following pairs:
 1. Van Gujjars — Punjab hills
 2. Bakarwals — Kashmir
 3. Gaddis — Andhra Pradesh → *1 and 2 only. The Gaddis were shepherds of **Kulu**; the Labadis were of Andhra.*
4. The "forest villages" established by the Forest Department were intended to — → *Ensure a regular supply of cheap labour, by allowing cultivation in the forest on condition that villagers worked for the Department.*

5. Consider the following: 1. Kol rebellion — 1831–32 2. Santhal revolt — 1855 3. Bastar rebellion — 1910 → *All three correctly matched.*
6. The political aim of Birsa Munda's movement was to — → *Drive out missionaries, moneylenders, landlords and the government, and set up a Munda Raj with Birsa at its head.*

Mains style

7. "*Colonial forest policy converted forest dwellers into forest labour.*" Discuss. **(250 words)**
8. Examine the impact of colonial land and forest laws on tribal societies, and trace their legacy in post-independence legislation. **(250 words)**
9. "*Birsa's vision of a golden age was a programme, not a nostalgia.*" Comment. **(150 words)**
10. "*Tribal resistance in colonial India was continuous and occasionally effective.*" Substantiate. **(150 words)**

Self-check (out loud, no notes):

- Describe *jhum* in six steps.
- What did tribal chiefs keep, and what did they lose?
- Explain the forest-village device in two sentences.
- State the silk cocoon price and the resale multiple.
- List six tribal revolts with dates.
- Give the four targets of Birsa's Munda Raj and the two outcomes of his movement.